

NOBLE FOUNDATION
FROM SLUMS TO SCHOOL BELLS

In the industrial hub of Ludhiana, Punjab, a silent revolution is taking place beneath railway bridges, inside cramped flat complexes, and on the fringes of urban slums. At the heart of this transformation is Rajinder Sharma, a social entrepreneur, and his organization, the Noble Foundation. This foundation has grown from a single impromptu gathering of slum children into a network of thirty schools today, educating thousands of underprivileged children and rewriting the destinies of families trapped in generational poverty.

THE SPARK OF AN IDEA

Before dedicating his life to philanthropy, Rajinder Sharma led a conventional life as an insurance officer, while actively participating in community activities. The turning point came during a poignant conversation with his wife, Anita Sharma. After he returned home with a generic wooden plaque from a community event, she motivated him to also engage in work that brought real benefit to society.

The very next morning, while driving past a local railway crossing lined with a cluster of slum dwellings, his wife pointed out towards children wandering aimlessly. Upon interviewing the children and their parents, Rajinder Sharma discovered a harsh reality: distance, safety concerns regarding the railway tracks, and acute poverty kept these children entirely out of the formal education system. He understood that without education, these children would not be able to come out of this poverty and have a good future. Moving quickly, he secured the use of a local Bhagwan Valmiki Dharamshala, and the first informal school was born. "Our philosophy is simple: if the child cannot reach the school, the school must go to the child," Rajinder Sharma says.

From its humble beginnings, the foundation expanded into high-need areas of Ludhiana city like the Bihari colony and Giaspura. By renting rooms or utilizing community spaces, the Noble foundation ensured that education became accessible, safe, and immediate. Today, the foundation is managing 30 schools - 26 in Ludhiana city and 4 in other districts of Punjab with a strength of 5000 students and 150 teachers. All students are provided with free books and uniform along withe free schooling. The yearly expenditure of approximately Rs.4 crore is managed entirely through transparent corporate social responsibility (CSR) channels and private goodwill.

INSTILLING DISCIPLINE, NUTRITION, AND SELF-WORTH

For Rajinder Sharma, running a school is not merely about alphabet charts and basic arithmetic; it is also about cultivating character and a lifelong healthy habits. The foundation enforces a strict code of discipline that applies equally to teachers, students and parents.

To combat late arrivals of students, the foundation introduced the "Punctuality Percentage" initiative. Parents who arrive with their children before the strict 8:00 AM bell receive special rewards. This simple mechanism flipped community standards; halls that once sat empty until 11:00 AM are now packed to capacity minutes before 8:00 AM.

Understanding that true development requires a healthy body alongside an active mind, the foundation has revolutionized the school routine by introducing a mandatory 'Fruit Break' for all



Fruit break



Piggy bank



Vocational training